

The Airtists are here

IF I HAD A RUPEE FOR EACH TIME A COOL NEW FEATURE IN AN UPCOMING GADGET WAS INDEED USING AN AI MODEL, THEN I'D BE JUST A FEW THOUSAND BUCKS RICHER.

Implementing an AI model is very easy these days. Most of the popular frameworks have plenty of ready-to-go models pre-baked into them. For example, image classifiers are one of the most common ones and all you need is a decently large labelled data set and you've got a production ready "Beta" feature that can be shipped immediately. The model can be fine-tuned later on to achieve a much higher accuracy and what better data set to train your model on than the data of your consumers? All you need to do is add a little clause in your privacy policy and all your consumers' data is yours for the taking.

New technologies are usually implemented where the said feature is most visible, where it can be easily advertised and where it can be easily distinguished as an add-on value rather than just a gimmick. It gives companies a justification to call their product better than the rest and also charge their consumers a little extra for including cutting-edge technology. The wow factor is what usually helps sell the product. Take for example, Facetune. It's a photo editing app that became a phenomenon in South-East Asia for the eerily accurate photo-edits that it enabled with just a few taps. That also helped the company behind Facetune raise more than 335 million dollars in funding.

The AI wave is also expected to nullify entire job pools where human resources are considered to be cheap labour and lacking function-critical skills. The most common example used is that of fast-food chains replacing the service staff with automatons that will be controlled by a central AI. The AI will be able to observe consumer patterns and handle resource management way better than any human can. It would also be incredibly cheap to have automated fast-food chains rather than employing a decent workforce. Of course, we won't be seeing automatons in developing countries where human labour is extremely cheap any time soon but it will eventually arrive. Fast Food service jobs are just one of the many sectors that are bound to see massive human attrition. Telemarketing, advertising and market research specialists are all jobs that are more or less

going to be nullified. Yes, there will be some function where human supervisors are required but the majority chunk will be replaced.

Proponents of AI always state that the job losses from one sector will always be compensated by new jobs created elsewhere. While that is true, what they don't bother saying is that the job creation is usually in a domain which requires skills of a much higher order. The person who served you the yummiest burger at the local fast food chain can't just leave the fast food job and become a data scientist to work on the very AI model that made him or her jobless in the first place. There is a good 5-10 year education / training period required to make that transition.

Then there are jobs that are believed to be irreplaceable by AI, any time soon. I had to add a caveat to that statement for obvious reasons. The epitome of human creativity, expressed in an art form was considered to be one of the last bastions where AI was unlikely to equal the greats. That's because AI was thought to not mimic an artist's mind. Unfortunately, that's one of the first things that AI models were taught to do. Text and image classification, as I pointed out earlier, is one of the first things AI was trained to operate on.

And to create new images, AI models use a technique called latent diffusion. With all the artworks created by the best of humanity available on Google, these AI models have been able to easily create awe-inspiring pieces of art with just a few text prompts. Think of what that means, they were actually right. AI will create as many, if not more jobs as it eliminates. An immensely higher order skill has been relegated so just a few words. A few words that every Tom, Dick and Harry can muster up. Did you have a Dosa today morning while reading a new article about the SpaceX Falcon 9 taking a Russian cosmonaut to the ISS? That's a prompt! Here's an artistic rendition of a cosmonaut having masala dosa while enjoying a picturesque evening on Mars. Please note: I shall now be taking commissions for a reasonable fee. 

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